Col. Henry Yule and A. C. Burnell, *HOBSON-JOBSON, A glossary of colloquial Anglo-Indian words and phrases*, 1886

Today the seafront at Puri looks very much like any other seaside resort, with a long sandy shore, the Golden Beach, lined by an esplanade, the Marine Drive, and backed by large hotel blocks catering for families on their annual holidays. Two centuries ago this seafront was almost entirely empty. A watercolour from 1820 (see page 205) shows a cluster of thatched bungalows on the beach put up for European visitors. Everything changed with the opening in 1888 of the Bengal Nagpur Railway's line linking Calcutta with Madras. For the first time Puri became accessible from virtually every corner of India.

Yet even before the railways Puri drew vast crowds, as a watercolour drawn in July 1818 by one of Colin Mackenzie's draughtsmen illustrates (see illustration). It shows the ceremony for which Puri was famous throughout India – and, to some degree, also notorious: the procession known as the *ratha yatra*, *or* 'chariot journey', in which three pyramidal carts with vast wooden wheels are drawn by hand in a procession that circles the central temple and its immediate environs. Each *ratha* contains one of a trinity of *murti*s, or 'images of deities', who normally reside on a platform in the innermost sanctum of the city's Jagannath temple: Krishna as Jagannath, 'lord of the universe', his brother Balabhadra and his sister Subhadra.

The anglicisation of the word 'Jagannath' into 'Juggernaut' and its corruption in the English dictionary into a pejorative meaning an unstoppable and merciless destructive force serves as a classic example of the colonial demonisation of the 'other' of the sort that made it possible for an otherwise decent man like the Christian evangelist and slavery abolitionist William Wilberforce to speak of Hinduism as 'one grand abomination, a dark and bloody superstition' and to describe the Hindu deities as 'absolute monsters of lust,